Airbus and 220 from Boeing—was valued at an estimated $70 billion (Rs 6 lakh crore) at listed prices. The orders span both narrowbody and widebody types, aimed at transforming Air India's domestic and international operations. To strengthen its narrowbody fleet, it has ordered 140 A320neos, 70 A321neos and 190 Boeing 737 MAX aircraft. Among widebodies, it has already inducted six A350-900s, with 34 larger A350-1000s due between 2025 and 2029. Deliveries of 20 Boeing 787-9s are expected to begin in late 2025, followed by 10 777-9s between 2025 and 2027. The carrier also holds purchase options for another 70 Boeing jets (50 737 MAXs and 20 787 Dreamliners), and a potential top-up order of 90 A320/A321neos and 10 A350s from Airbus, for delivery between 2029 and 2034. That would take the total to 640 aircraft under the new deals.

IndiGo, meanwhile, is doubling down on Airbus. It has 916 aircraft pending delivery as of June 2025, including 500 firm orders for A320neos placed in 2023—125 of the base model and 375 of the extended A321neos. All are scheduled for delivery by 2035. Its long-haul ambitions rest on 69 A321XLRs, arriving between 2026 and 2029, and 60 A350-900 widebodies, to be delivered over eight years from 2027 to 2035, with the option to purchase 40 more. While A320neo deliveries are already under way, the bulk of its A321neos are slated to join the fleet after 2030.

Leading long-haul carriers like Qatar Airways and Emirates operate far more advanced widebody fleets, yet their average fleet ages are similar to Air India's. Qatar's 233-aircraft fleet averages seven years and includes a balanced mix of narrowbody (A320s, 737 MAX) and widebody (A350s, 787s, and 777s) jets. Emirates, with an all-widebody fleet of 260—A380s and 777s—has an average age of 10.5 years for its aircraft. Air India, meanwhile, is inducting new models like the A350-900 and investing $400 million (Rs 3,450 crore) to upgrade 106 existing aircraft—including cabin interiors and inflight systems—but analysts say it will still take several years before a consistently modern onboard experience becomes standard across its legacy fleet.

CHALLENGE 3
CRACKS IN MAINTENANCE

All aircraft need to go through routine maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO), a comprehensive set of activities focusing on aircraft safety, airworthiness and operational efficiency. Maintenance includes routine pre-flight checks. "Before disinvestment, Air India's aircraft were being maintained internally by its engineering department, which was later turned into a subsidiary (AIESL)," says Jitender Bhargava, a former executive director of the airline. Experts feel that AIESL could have been bundled along with Air India when it was sold to the Tatas. The Centre, perhaps, was looking at higher monetary gains by disinvesting it at a later date.

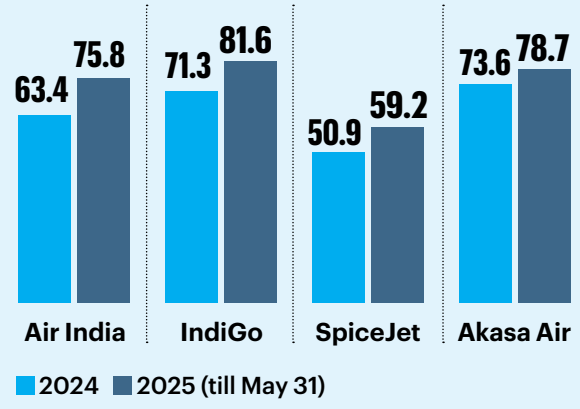
AIESL, however, is not Air India's sole MRO partner. The airline is in the process of building an MRO facility of its own in Bengaluru. It has also entered into strategic agreements, including a 12-year inventory technical management agreement with SIA Engineering Company, Singapore, to support its Airbus A320 family fleet. The airline has another multi-year agreement with Lufthansa Technik for total component support for its Boeing 777 fleet and has a long-term agreement with the US-based Honeywell for aftermarket support for both its existing and new fleet. Air India even came under scrutiny following Operation Sindoor, after it emerged that it had outsourced some MRO work for its Boeing 777 fleet to Turkish Technic—raising concerns due to Turkey's overt support for Pakistan. In early June, Wilson said the airline

THE SERVICE RECORD

PUNCTUALITY

Performance picks up across the board, but Air India still trails IndiGo and Akasa

Average on-time performance of scheduled flights (%)





"As a confidence-building measure, we have elected to continue enhanced pre-flight safety checks on our Boeing 787 fleet and, as an added measure, our Boeing 777 aircraft, for the time being"

— CAMPBELL WILSON
MD & CEO, Air India, in a statement on Jun. 19